

Budget Engagement Report 2026/27

Introduction

From 22 September - 19 October 2025, we engaged with people who live, work and study in Lambeth to better understand their priorities and perspectives around our budget challenge.

The **aim** of this engagement exercise was to:

- raise awareness amongst residents and stakeholders of the extent of Lambeth's budget challenge
- ask for suggestions as to how to prioritise council spending, as well as asking for suggestions as to how to raise and save money

During the engagement period we:

- Hosted a survey on the council's engagement platform, GoVocal
- Distributed hard copies of the survey to our libraries
- Deployed our market researchers to libraries, leisure centres and markets, in addition to the Health and Wellbeing Bus and a Housing 'Meet the Landlord event' in order to assist with the completion of surveys
- Attended several online and in person engagement meetings and events, to promote the survey and to have focused discussions on topics relating directly to the survey

Survey

In addition to the core survey, we also produced an easy read version. In total we received:

- **5155** core survey responses
- **34** easy read survey responses (13 paper copies were started but not completed)

Of the core survey responses:

- **415** were completed face to face with support from the market researchers
- **57** paper copies were completed in libraries
- **4683** were completed online
- Of the Easy Read surveys, **33 out of 34** were completed in libraries
- **37** people who completed the survey said they were doing so on behalf of an organisation

Survey respondents were self-selecting so should not be treated as representative of the Lambeth population as a whole. Through using a range of methods including events with service users, the council sought to ensure a wide range of residents had the opportunity to complete the survey in line with our commitment to equity in everything we do.

Communication and promotion

We delivered a cost-effective multi-channel campaign that reached communities across the whole borough and was seen over one million times. This included:

- Email newsletters to residents and stakeholders
- Social media content, including videos explaining our budget challenge and digital marketing
- Posters and leaflets distributed to community and council buildings across Lambeth, including libraries, leisure and sports centres, VCS organisations, community halls and hubs.
- Feature story in Lambeth Talk, sent to every household and business address in the borough.

Other engagement

During this period, we attended the following events to promote the survey:

- Voluntary and Community Sector Network event (in person)
- Violence Against Women and Girls Forum (online)
- Lambeth Forum Network meeting (online)

To have more detailed discussions with young people aged 12-25, alongside our survey-related engagement, we held conversations at the following events:

- Children in Care Council (in person)
- SEND Youth Council (in person)
- Youth Council (in person)

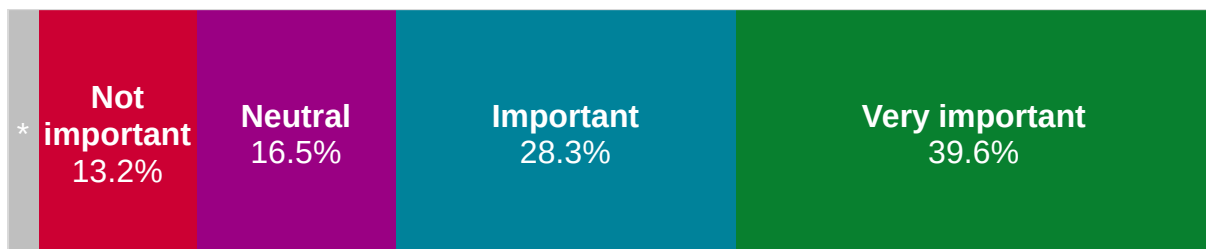
Feedback from young people

Across the three groups we spoke to their top three priorities for council spending were:

- Helping people with housing
- Schools and employment
- Helping vulnerable adults

Maintaining services for vulnerable people

Overall, **67.8%** of respondents to our core survey indicated that maintaining services for vulnerable people was **important or very important** to them. The split is demonstrated below:



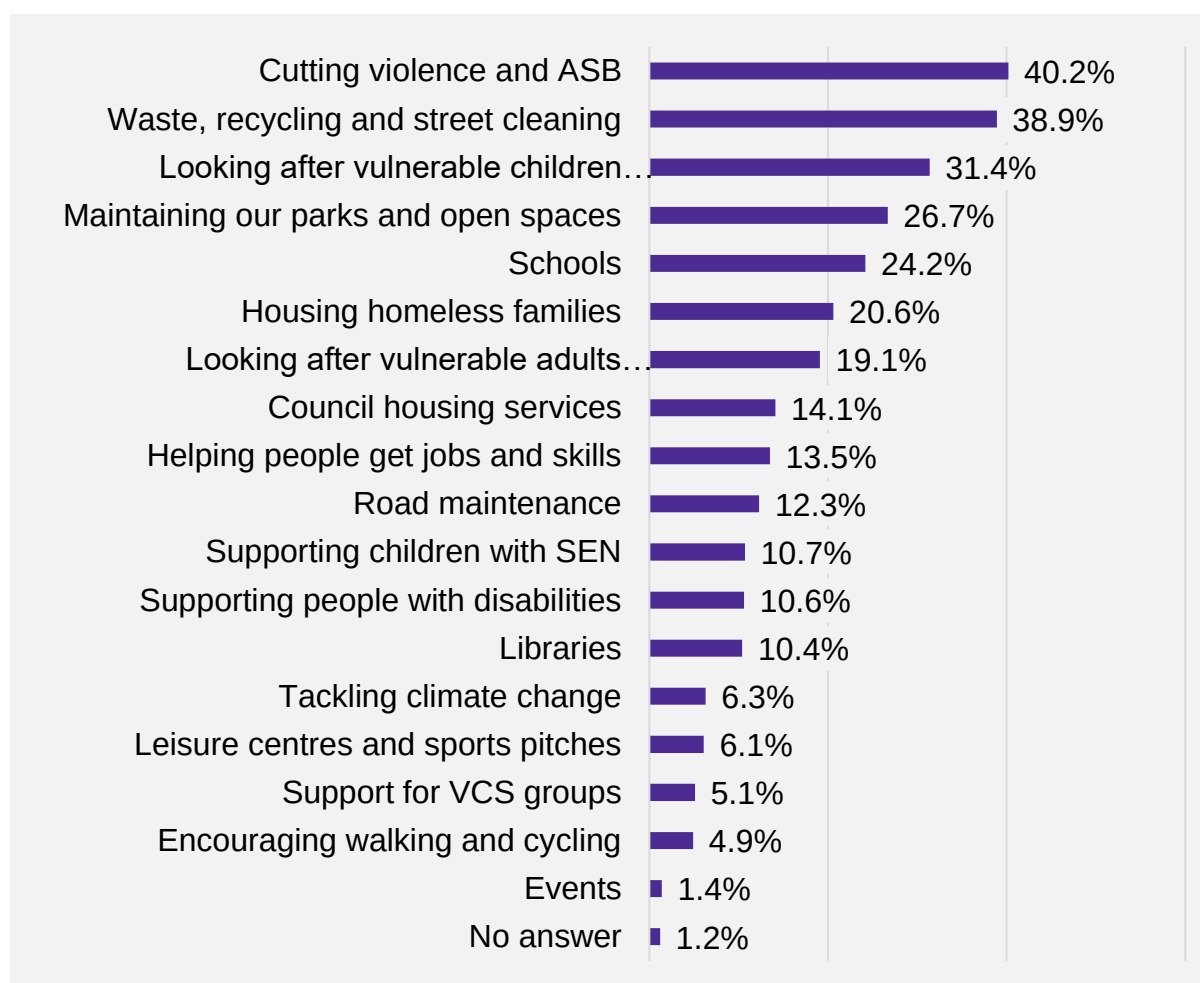
** 2.5% (128) non-responses*

Some groups of residents were more likely to find this important compared to others. Particularly, residents who are:

- ❖ Female
- ❖ Black / Black British
- ❖ Older (aged 55 and over)
- ❖ Younger (aged 18-24)
- ❖ Disabled
- ❖ Often in contact with the council
- ❖ Living in social rented accommodation
- ❖ Not in employment (including full-time students and retirees)

Priorities for spending

When asked for their top three priorities for the council to spend money on, the most selected priority was **'cutting violence and anti-social behaviour'**. This was chosen by 40% of respondents. The second and third-most popular priorities were **'waste, recycling and street cleaning'**, and **children's social care**, which were chosen by 39% and 31% of respondents, respectively.

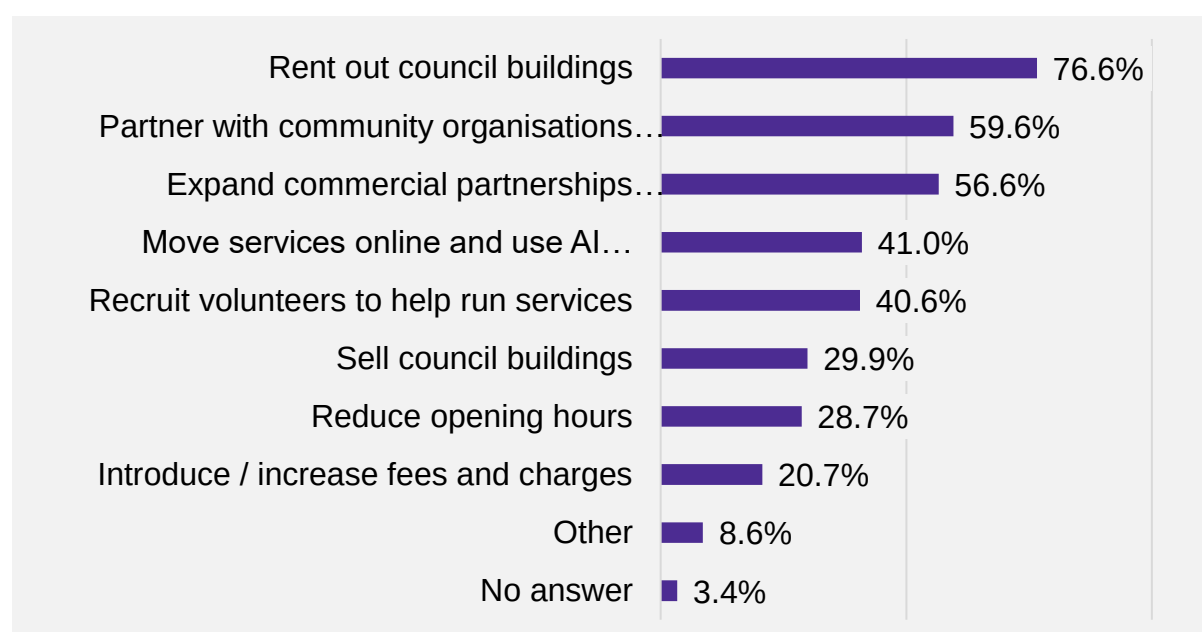


Statistical testing has identified several differences between groups in the borough – particularly according to gender, ethnicity, age, disability, housing tenure, economic activity, and how frequently one is in contact with the council. Generally, residents who are male and residents who own their homes were more likely to prioritise more 'universal' issues – such as violence and ASB, waste and street cleaning, parks, and road maintenance. Meanwhile, residents who are female, Black / Black British, disabled, and/or live in social rented accommodation, were more likely to select priorities like looking after vulnerable children and adults, schools, housing homeless families, and council housing services.

Moreover, respondents were also asked to share why they chose their priorities, and 1,964 (38.1%) provided a comment. The vast majority of these reiterated their support for what they chose rather than explain their reasoning in particular detail. Nonetheless, the most popular substantive reason was to **focus on statutory and basic services for local government** (4.0% of responses). Some respondents also objected to being asked to prioritise spend in the first place (3.5%).

Saving or raising funds

When asked to select which money-saving or –raising measures they agree with the council should consider, respondents' most preferred approach was **renting out council buildings to other organisations**. This was agreed with by over **3 in 4** respondents. The majority of respondents also supported **partnering with community organisations to deliver services** where that can help deliver them at a lower cost (60%) and **expanding commercial partnerships**, such as events, film shoots, sponsorship and private venue hire (57%).



There are also several differences between groups of residents here. Generally, residents who are men, LGB+, White British and/or owner-occupiers were more likely to agree with almost all measures, particularly when compared to their female, heterosexual, Black / Black British, and social renter counterparts.

When asked whether they had any additional suggestions for how the council can **save** money, 1,630 respondents provided a comment. Every comment has been read and manually allocated one or more themes, which have been counted and shown below.

Suggestions varied considerably, however **1 in 5 mentioned reducing staff pay** (usually for the highest-paid staff) **or changing working conditions** (such as mandating longer working hours for the same pay or reducing pensions and other staff benefits). There were a range of comments regarding improving organisational efficiency in general, and a range of service specific comments regarding improving housing management, ending low-traffic neighbourhoods, and making more use of volunteers and local groups.

Rank	Theme (Ways to save)	Occurrences	% responses
1	Reduce staff pay and/or change conditions	315	19.3%
2	Improve efficiency	230	14.1%
3	Stop LTNs	209	12.8%
4	Other / specific suggestions	183	11.2%
5	Housing reform (incl. management and TA)	138	8.5%
6	More use of volunteers and local groups	123	7.5%
7	'Get the basics right' and improve standards	117	7.2%
8	Better contract management	99	6.1%
9	Use of partnerships	98	6.0%
10	Sell and/or rent assets	93	5.7%
11	Use technology and AI	90	5.5%
12	Cut non-essential services / 'vanity projects'	70	4.3%
13	In-sourcing / reduce consultants	69	4.2%
14	Better financial control	69	4.2%
15	Increase fines and charges	65	4.0%
16	Don't use AI	57	3.5%
17	Benefit reform and/or reduction	53	3.3%
18	Stop EDI initiatives	49	3.0%
19	Prevention and/or spend to save	46	2.8%
20	Avoid and/or reduce legal fees	45	2.8%
21	Don't sell assets	42	2.6%
22	Tax reform (incl. council tax and business rates)	41	2.5%
23	Fraud prevention	40	2.5%
24	Reduce printing (such as leaflets and letters)	38	2.3%
25	Political reform (incl. reduced allowances)	34	2.1%

Rank	Theme (Ways to save)	Occurrences	% responses
26	Don't increase charges	34	2.1%
27	Organisational culture change	27	1.7%
28	Don't do events	27	1.7%
29	Lobby the Government	26	1.6%
30	Do events to fundraise	23	1.4%
31	Improve energy efficiency	17	1.0%
32	Reform SEND provision	8	0.5%

When asked whether they had any additional suggestions for how the council can **raise** money, 1,315 respondents provided a comment. Every comment has been read and manually allocated one or more themes, which have been counted and shown below.

The diversity and spread of themes here reflect the range of services that the council runs and ideas from residents about opportunities to raise money. Most notably, the most suggested idea was to make more use of commercial events to raise money, followed by putting **council assets up for sale or rent**, and **increased fines and improved enforcement** to raise money.

Rank	Theme (Ways to raise)	Occurrences	% responses
1	Other / specific suggestions	259	19.7%
2	More use of commercial events	173	13.2%
3	Put council assets up for sale or rent	167	12.7%
4	Increased fines / improved enforcement	147	11.2%
5	Increase council tax	124	9.4%
6	Increase fees and charges (e.g., for parking)	109	8.3%
7	Implement efficiency savings / reduce waste	106	8.1%
8	Cut staff pay, headcount, and/or benefits	106	8.1%
9	Fundraising (e.g., for specific projects)	76	5.8%
10	Housing reform (e.g., improved management)	73	5.6%
11	Implement a wealth tax	71	5.4%
12	Lobby the Government	63	4.8%
13	Partnerships with the VCS and/or private sector	59	4.5%
14	Landlord and/or Airbnb levies	50	3.8%

Rank	Theme (Ways to raise)	Occurrences	% responses
15	Support businesses	50	3.8%
16	Discretionary charging	43	3.3%
17	No LTNs	42	3.2%
18	Drawing on volunteering	36	2.7%
19	Sponsorships	31	2.4%
20	Donations (financial or in kind)	31	2.4%
21	Charge cyclists and/or e-bikes	29	2.2%
22	Improve energy efficiency and use of green energy	27	2.1%
23	Increase business rates	27	2.1%
24	'Get the basics right' and improve standards	27	2.1%
25	Learn from and work with other councils	27	2.1%
26	Improve contract management	24	1.8%
27	Provide advertising space	22	1.7%
28	Prevention and/or spend to save	21	1.6%
29	Improve debt collection	17	1.3%
30	Change political leadership	16	1.2%
31	Utilise tourists (incl. implementing a tourist tax)	15	1.1%
32	Bring more services in house	14	1.1%

Easy Read survey responses

We received 34 Easy Read survey responses.

In these, **48.5%** of respondents agreed we **should keep helping people who need care and housing, even if it means stopping doing other things**. Just 15.2% disagreed, with the rest either not being sure or not answering.

The top three priorities for spend were slightly different from our main survey, but helping vulnerable children was a priority across both surveys:

1. **Helping older people who need care**
2. **Helping children who need care**
3. **Schools**

The top three methods to save and raise money align with the results from our main survey:

1. **Make money by doing things like hosting events, filming, or renting out spaces (55.9%)**
2. **Rent out council buildings to other groups (50%)**
3. **Work with community groups to run services more cheaply (32.4%)**

Some respondents raised concerns about council communication and accessibility, suggesting the council should listen more to residents and not exclude those who are not online. There were also calls for better procurement, contract management, and ensuring value for money.

Organisational survey responses

We received 37 responses from people who said they represented an organisation.

73% of these respondents indicated that maintaining services for vulnerable people was **important or very important** to them.

The top four priorities for spend were slightly different from those who responded as individuals but helping vulnerable children was a priority for both. It is perhaps not surprising that support for voluntary and community groups was seen as a key priority for this cohort as most organisational respondents were responding on behalf of a voluntary or community group:

1. **Looking after vulnerable children (11)**
2. **Looking after vulnerable adults (10)**
3. **Council housing services (10)**
4. **Support for voluntary and community groups (10)**

The top three methods to save and raise money from these respondents differ slightly from those who responded as individuals, with agreement around renting out council buildings, partnering with community organisations and expanding commercial partnerships. Recruiting volunteers also featured as a priority.

1. **Partner with community organisations to deliver services where than can help deliver them at a lower cost (24)**
2. **Rent out council buildings to other organisations (23)**
3. **Recruit volunteers to help run services (14)**
4. **Expand commercial partnerships (14)**

Next Steps

This engagement exercise has provided the council with significant insights into resident's views about budget priorities which have been considered by the council's Corporate Leadership Team as part of developing recommendations for the council's Medium Term Financial Strategy and 2026/27 Budget setting process.

Over two-thirds of residents indicated that maintaining services for vulnerable people was important or very important to them and that has been a core part of the

council's budget setting approach. Many services for vulnerable people are statutory requirements for the council to carry out, and while ensuring every service is delivered in the most efficient way possible is a key aim of our financial transformation, protecting vulnerable people has been at the heart of the budget decisions the council has made. This is particularly true in relation to looking after vulnerable children which was the one of the top three priorities selected by residents in the survey to spend money on. The council has increased its spending on children and young people by over £32 million in the last three years, and our budget proposals are focused on investing in intervening earlier to help reduce the number of children taken into care, to boost the number of in-house foster carers and to support more children out of care and into more suitable and permanent accommodation and support that better suits their needs. This is a key aim of recent government policy changes to embed a Families First approach which the council welcomes alongside the additional government investment for support for children and young people made through the recent Fair Funding reforms.

The most selected priority by residents was around cutting violence and anti-social behaviour. The council has successfully lobbied to increase community policing in recent years and has boosted its on street presence in town centres with street warden patrols alongside using CCTV to provide community reassurance and deter anti-social behaviour. We will continue to prioritise tackling anti-social behaviour alongside the council's award-winning work to tackle violence against those most likely to experience it - young people and women and girls. The third most selected priority was waste, recycling and street cleaning. The council is prioritising this area in this budget and we will continue to improve and enhance street cleanliness and cracking down on fly tipping through enforcement and quick responses to reported incidents.

Residents who completed the council's budget survey showed significant support for a range of ways to save or raise money that the council is already progressing as part of our drive to use council taxpayers' money as efficiently as possible. That includes renting out council buildings to other organisations, with the council already having reduced its office footprint significantly in the last few years by reducing core council buildings from 14 down to 2 and progressing plans to rent out floor space in the Civic Centre subject to agreeing appropriate lettings. The majority of respondents also supported partnering with community organisations to deliver services where that can help deliver them at a lower cost, which is a core part of the council's service delivery model across a range of services including health and social care and youth services. Residents were also keen to see an expansion of commercial partnerships, including holding more commercial events to help generate income to maintain key services which is a core part of the council's Events Strategy. There were also a range of organisational efficiency suggestions which are key features of the council's financial management approach, including reducing the number of

senior staff at the highest grades in the council by 20%, reducing the number of council directorates from seven to five and using technology to make services more efficient and effective for residents.

We'd like to express our thanks to all residents and community organisations who took the time to share their views and suggestions about how we can work together to tackle the council's budget challenge.